

REFLECTIONS



Vincent A. V-S.

MULAN - Poem

I met a girl.

She showed herself to me.

I met a girl.

But she wouldn't give herself to me.

This must be how it felt
for all my "loves" I left hopeless—
high and dry,
left pondering what they did wrong.
Asking themselves
how this could be?

I met a girl.

She showed herself to me.

But she wouldn't give herself to me.

I pondered where I went wrong.

I manifested her as quickly as I destroyed her being—
a bittersweet familiarity.

ON PAIN AND DISCIPLINE

Some time ago, I began using shock therapy. I bought a watch that's designed to send electric shocks to my wrist at a specific time or whenever I pushed the shock button.

I first began training myself to wake up early—in the same way that Nobel Prize-winning physiologist, Ivan Pavlov, famously trained his dog to salivate when he rang a bell. That's why the watch is called the Pavlok 3.

It worked so well, I had to stop using it—typical of me, I guess. Who wants to wake up at 5:30 AM for their accounting job anyway. I'd rather burn the midnight oil.

But it wasn't long before I began using the watch for a different purpose—shocking myself whenever I had negative thoughts. That worked even better; I found myself not needing to use it.

Then, months later, with the watch on my wrist, I suddenly became so frustrated with my behavior that I repeatedly slapped myself on the head—hard—like a man who had lost his way.

I sat there with my tail between my legs—calm, disciplined, scared—like the feelings I had after mommy and daddy spanked me with a belt—like when dad slapped both sides of my head with both of his hands at the same time when I was 13.

Surreal—it was surreal because it worked and sent me back to childhood. Surreal—because I understood it—slapping myself.

Was it an epiphany?

And why do it? The domestication of my childhood, perhaps—could it have conditioned me to change my behavior only in response to physical and emotional pain?

Maybe that's why I once dented my dad's Hummer with my fist and broke numerous phones by throwing them against walls and floors.

As I thought about those acts, I could only think of them as normal human behavior—at least in my family.

My mom and dad might say, "I don't slap myself on the head, and my parents spanked me," to which I would reply:

Yeah, but you slapped me on the head and whipped me with a belt when you were angry. Is it not a pattern?

Though I no longer punch things and try my best not to break valuables, I wonder if I've only lessened the severity of the punishment I inflict on myself.

Will I ever learn to cope differently?

And how should I defend myself when family members suggest I should be pathologized and medicated again?

As far as I'm concerned, intensity is not illness. I've been medicated before. I know what that experience was like for me. Right now, I don't feel delusional or out of control. I'm reflective. I'm functional. I'm choosing to understand patterns in my behavior, not suppress them. If I ever felt medication was necessary, I would take that seriously—but I'm not there.

Not everything that makes other people uncomfortable is something I need to fix.

Depth ≠ Danger

Honesty ≠ Instability

Don't worry. I'm okay. I'm just exploring the crevices of my identity.

SELF-IDENTITY

I only worked 11 nonconsecutive months out of the last 24. At first it was forced on me. But the vacation showed me a better life, and from there, it became my decision to remain unemployed and only work a minimum amount of time.

I got a taste of the woods, and I can't see myself going back. I regained my sense of self-identity—the one I gave up to stupidly pursue a career as an accountant. And then I lost it again as I toiled night and day for a month, moving my belongings from an apartment to a storage unit. It's amazing how unwanted work can do that to a person so quickly. But I've learned: self-identity is never far away—just covered.

INTERLUDE 1

One thing you'll never know—because you can't—is whether the near loss of this van's roof was caused by me.



Scratches?

Me? No—that's impossible.

As my father would say as a child whenever he clearly made a mess: "Probably Jimmy did it," blaming his older brother.

ON FORGETFULNESS

Since moving from what some people would consider a *luxury apartment* to a home that resembles a child's fort, I've become much more forgetful than usual. No more tiny boxes for all my belongings; I simply don't have the space. But what I do have is yarn, and yarn I will tie to myself on one end and to my belongings on the other ends. Never again will I forget my gym towel, underwear, lighter, nor misplace things in the most curious locations.

But I can't promise that I'll remember to put water in my teacup—the final task that commences the act of making tea—because making tea is only a 10-minute process full of things that could distract me from the thing I was just doing.

What was I just doing? Ah, yes, the tea. Where is it?

Also, where'd my cup go?

As his blood begins to boil.

I JUST HAD MY CUP, GODDAMMIT! IT WAS LITERALLY IN MY HANDS SECONDS AGO.

NOW IT VANISHED?

IT'S GONE?

ARE YOU FUCKING KIDDING ME?

IS THIS WHAT I DESERVE?

SON OF GODDAMN, STUPID SHIT, GOTTA BE LOSING

EVERYTHI—ah, there it is, my cup, sitting tranquilly in my toiletries bag near my left foot.

In hindsight, it was actually the perfect spot to place it—if only I would have made a note to self: teacup in toiletries bag (left foot).

But of course, that won't be a problem once I attach yarn to everything and then tie said yarn to myself. That's when the real growth will start happening.

You just watch.

Wait and see!

You're not gonna recognize me.

~ With Love,
Vincent A. V-S.
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